

Re: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Mher Avetisyan

Thu 7/23/2026 5:15 PM

To: Zhenyu Wang <zhenyu.wang@tum.de>;

Dear Zhenyu,
Thank you for the clarification.

I understand that I should follow the existing LaTeX template and focus on the thesis content rather than adapting the document to a separate citation standard.
I will proceed accordingly and concentrate on consolidating the empirical results, writing the main chapters, and documenting the methodology and limitations clearly.
I will now go ahead and contact Ramla to complete the formal registration of my thesis.

Thank you once again for your assistance. Please, let me know if anything else is needed from your side.
Best regards,
Mher Avetisyan

From: Zhenyu Wang
Sent: Thursday, July 23, 2026 4:50:03 PM
To: Mher Avetisyan
Subject: RE: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Hi Mher,

Actually, whether it is APA 6, APA 7, or IEEE style, none of these are relevant to us.
Thesis and papers are written differently, so we only need to follow the format of this latex file.

At the same time, because we are using latex, we only need to consider the text content. No matter what formatting requirements may arise later, we only need to copy and paste the text content, and there is no need to make too many formatting adaptations.

So please do not get too hung up on the formatting.

Best,
Zhenyu

From: Mher Avetisyan <mher.avetisyan@tum.de>
Date: Thursday, 23. July 2026 at 15:22
To: Zhenyu Wang <zhenyu.wang@tum.de>
Subject: Re: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Dear Zhenyu,

Thank you very much for your reply and for clarifying these points. I hope the workshop went well.

Your confirmation regarding the revised title, research question, estimand, claim strength, and empirical scope is very helpful. Based on this, I will proceed with consolidating the completed analysis and focus primarily on writing, citations, and presentation, apart from corrections and the already planned robustness checks.

Regarding the data, I have substantial progress and now have suitable, reproducible public data for the two main empirical parts of the thesis:

1. For the first part, we use IMF PortWatch data to estimate the disruption-associated shortfall in tanker throughput through the Strait of Hormuz relative to counterfactual paths trained exclusively on pre-disruption data.
2. For the second part, we use public vessel, terminal, trade, and customs data to study the physical LNG reallocation mechanism. This allows us to examine changes in terminal-to-terminal patterns, voyage distance, inferred capacity-nautical miles, vessel-time requirements, and importer or destination-basin exposure. We keep the measurement limitations explicit and do not treat inferred vessel capacity as observed cargo volume.

The remaining data limitation concerns the monetary transmission layer. I have not found a freely accessible and consistently defined LNG freight-rate series with sufficient pre- and post-disruption coverage. The relevant Spark freight-rate series appears to require proprietary access. Therefore, freight-rate effects cannot currently be evaluated with the same empirical reliability and would remain an optional extension if access becomes available. This limitation does not affect the two completed empirical parts described above.

I also had one short clarification regarding citations. I reviewed the LaTeX template you shared, but I could not find a prescribed citation style. The template currently contains an adaptable default rather than an explicit departmental requirement. Should I use APA6 or APA7, or, as it was done in the paper shared by professor, the IEEE citation style?

Thank you again for your guidance. If you require, I will also organize the completed results, remaining limitations, and any issues into a concise progress report for you.

Best regards,
Mher Avetisyan

From: Zhenyu Wang
Sent: Thursday, July 23, 2026 2:43:17 PM
To: Mher Avetisyan
Subject: RE: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Hi Mher,

Sorry for the late reply, since we are too busy and just finished our own workshop. And there are too many things need to be collected.

[Regarding question 1 Is this revised title, research question, estimand, and claim strength acceptable? And question 2 Is the completed empirical scope sufficient for a Bachelor's thesis?]

Yes, of course it's acceptable.

Actually, the dataset never really matters. Once you have a “random” dataset, define some reasonable research questions, implement some SOTA models, and get some reasonable results, everything is acceptable.

So I would strongly recommend that you not get too hung up on the dataset issue, because it is not important. If a certain method or model only works on a specific dataset, that means the method or model is too poor. So if finding a dataset is really too difficult, are there any public datasets that fit this topic?

[Regarding question 3 May I now freeze the empirical scope, apart from corrections or specifically requested robustness checks, and focus exclusively on writing, citations, and presentation?

And question 4 Which citation style should I use?]

I would recommend that use the latex template. <https://github.com/fwalch/tum-thesis-latex>

[Regarding question 5 What main-text page length do you expect, and are the bibliography and appendices excluded from that count?]

Some other students asked this question as well, but Prof. Li did not reply yet.

Empirically, introduction + related works sections maximum up to 30%.

Of course, the more content you try to study, the easier it becomes in the end, because you can selectively choose good results and the points you want to express to include in the main text, and put the rest in the supplementary material.

In addition, if there is any progress, you can organize it into a report and send it to me, so that I may better understand the issues you are encountering.

I hope these information can answer your questions.

Best,
Zhenyu

From: Mher Avetisyan <mher.avetisyan@tum.de>

Date: Monday, 20. July 2026 at 18:46

To: Zhenyu Wang <zhenyu.wang@tum.de>

Subject: Re: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Dear Zhenyu Wang,
As a brief addition to my previous email,

I am continuing to search for suitable alternatives to the Spark Commodities freight-rate data. I have contacted and registered with several established data providers, but I have not yet received confirmation of access or permission to use their data for academic research.

This ongoing search does not change the scope proposed in my earlier email. If suitable data become available in time, I would be happy to incorporate them as an extension. Otherwise, I will proceed with the completed public-data analysis and focus on finalizing the manuscript.

I will inform you if I receive any relevant access or approval.

Kind regards,
Mher Avetisyan

From: Mher Avetisyan
Sent: Monday, July 20, 2026 12:51:13 PM
To: Zhenyu Wang
Subject: Thesis scope confirmation and formal writing requirements

Dear Zhenyu Wang,

I would like to confirm the final scope of my Bachelor's thesis before I freeze the empirical analysis and concentrate exclusively on completing the manuscript.

The original proposal focused on identifying the ton-mile multiplier through LNG freight rates and proprietary vessel data. Because the required Spark freight-rate and commercial AIS data were not available, I proceeded with the approved public-data pathway. The work completed so far consists of:

- A counterfactual analysis of the 2026 Strait of Hormuz tanker-throughput disruption using IMF PortWatch data. Daily tanker transit count is the primary outcome, with deadweight capacity as a secondary robustness outcome.
- Models trained exclusively on pre-disruption data with chronological validation, uncertainty intervals, temporal and spatial placebos, synthetic-control analysis, and Bayesian structural time-series corroboration.
- An LNG-specific mechanism layer using Global Fishing Watch vessel events, the WTO/AXSMarine LNG outbound index, terminal sequences, and official importer statistics.
- Estimates of inferred nominal capacity-distance, modeled vessel-days, destination exposure, and changes in importer sourcing patterns. These are presented as measurement and mechanism evidence, not as observed cargo ton-miles.
- A reproducible data and analysis pipeline with provenance controls, automated checks, generated tables and figures, and a working manuscript draft.

The proposed primary research question is:

"How large and persistent was the disruption-associated shortfall in observable daily tanker throughput through the Strait of Hormuz relative to counterfactual paths estimated exclusively from pre-disruption data?"

The proposed title is:

"Counterfactual Estimation of Tanker-Throughput Disruption at the Strait of Hormuz: Forecasting and Synthetic-Control Evidence from the 2026 Episode"

The thesis would deliberately report a "disruption-associated counterfactual shortfall," rather than a causal ATT or an LNG freight-rate effect. The LNG vessel and importer analyses would serve as supporting mechanism evidence. Spark freight-rate data would remain an optional addition only if suitable access became available in time.

Could you advise on the points below, or forward those requiring the Professor's decision?

1. Is this revised title, research question, estimand, and claim strength acceptable?
2. Is the completed empirical scope sufficient for a Bachelor's thesis?
3. May I now freeze the empirical scope, apart from corrections or specifically requested robustness checks, and focus exclusively on writing, citations, and presentation?
4. Which citation style should I use? The current draft I have made uses APA 6, but I can change it if the Chair requires another style or edition.

5. What main-text page length do you expect, and are the bibliography and appendices excluded from that count? My current target is approximately 40 main-text pages.

A short response to these five points would help me finalize the thesis consistently and avoid adding unnecessary analyses.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration.

Kind regards,

Mher Avetisyan